AmeriHealth / Q-Care Affordable Medical Care Clinical Policy Bulletin: Advanced Imaging - Lumbar Spine MRI Policy Number: AMH-RAD-2026 **Effective Date:** January 1, 2026

I. Policy Statement Advanced imaging of the lumbar spine (MRI) is considered medically necessary when the patient meets ONE of the following criteria:

A. Presence of "Red Flag" Symptoms:

1. Progressive severe neurologic deficit (e.g., bowel/bladder incontinence, saddle anesthesia).
2. Suspected spinal infection or spinal tumor.
3. Severe trauma resulting in suspected fracture.

B. Failure of Conservative Therapy:

1. Patient presents with radicular pain, spinal stenosis, or persistent low back pain.
2. Patient has completed a minimum of six (6) weeks of documented conservative therapy, which must include BOTH: a. Active physical therapy (minimum 2 sessions per week). b. Pharmacologic intervention (NSAIDs, muscle relaxants, or neuropathic pain agents).
3. Conservative therapy has failed to improve the patient's symptoms or symptoms have worsened.

II. Documentation Requirements All prior authorization and claims submissions must include provider clinical notes explicitly detailing the duration and outcome of conservative therapy, or explicitly documenting red flag symptoms. Claims lacking this documentation will be denied as not medically necessary.